

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

A professional to the core, he turned down a cameo in *Dhurandhar The Revenge* due to a prior commitment. He calls it his loss but would not cancel on a filmmaker he had given dates to

On nepotism in the film industry, he is blunt. Access may be easier, but "you can't win over the love of the audience" without hard work. "It's the audience which decides," he says

> **I am a good listener and I listen to people who are much more sensible, much more intelligent. And always surround myself with people who know more than me**
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> **I am what I am because of my wife, because of my family**
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> **You change, you move on, you reinvent. Don't be delusional. Do what you feel you can. Because I love this craft, I love acting...as long as I am working, I am improving my craft. Life is beautiful**

became a signature. "The stubble became so synonymous with me... but the moustache—nobody wanted to accept it. They said no one with a moustache can become a big star." He proved otherwise.

The same openness drove his decision to join *Slumdog Millionaire*. Kapoor signed on without a fee. The film has paid back £500,000 (about Rs 6.2 crore) in royalties over the years, but its real value lies elsewhere. "I had the opportunity of travelling, meeting [new people], and it opened me up. I worked with 300 people whom I didn't know, and then I did [the series] *24*. I stayed in LA. That was a great learning curve."

That's not a bad journey for a man who failed to land a spot in the acting course at the Film and Television Institute of India in the '70s. "You go through all kinds of insecurities in life," he said, "but ultimately it's your hard work, commitment" that matter. ■